

IMPACT OF CUSTOMS ANTI-SMUGGLING OPERATIONS AT SEME BORDER, NIGERIA

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Abstract

This article critically examines the impact of anti-smuggling operations at the Seme border, one of Nigeria's busiest and most strategic international trade corridors. It focuses on the social, economic and security outcomes arising from sustained enforcement activities by the Nigeria Customs Service. Over the years the Seme border has served as a major route for illicit trade, including smuggling of rice, petroleum products, arms and narcotics, thereby posing significant threats to national security and development. The paper evaluates key interventions adopted by the NCS, particularly the 2019 border closure under Operation SWIFT RESPONSE, which aimed to curb trans-border crimes and strengthen economic regulation. It assesses how these measures influenced revenue generation, domestic industrial growth and reduction in illegal imports. Additionally, the article analyzes the broader implications of anti-smuggling operations on community wellbeing, including crime reduction, improved border security and enhanced institutional effectiveness. By integrating empirical data, policy analysis and documented outcomes, the article provides a comprehensive understanding of how anti-smuggling strategies at the Seme border contribute to national development, while also highlighting associated trade-offs and policy challenges.

Key Words: *Nigeria Customs Service (NCS), Anti-smuggling operations, Seme Border, Border security, Illicit trade,*

Introduction

Smuggling remains a major global security and economic challenge undermining governance and facilitating transnational crime. The United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime estimates that illicit trade constitutes over 10 per cent of global commerce, generating hundreds of billions of dollars annually (UNODC 2020). Recent enforcement data highlights the scale of the threat. In 2024, Nigerian authorities intercepted over 800 rifles and 100,000 rounds of ammunition in a single operation, demonstrating the growing sophistication of illicit networks (Reuters 2024). Similarly, large consignments of narcotics and counterfeit pharmaceuticals continue to circulate globally, reinforcing the linkage between smuggling, organized crime and insecurity.

West Africa has become a critical hub for illicit trafficking due to porous borders and weak enforcement capacity. Nigeria alone has over 1,499 illegal entry routes, facilitating cross-border smuggling of arms, drugs and contraband goods (RSIS International 2024). Recent data shows intensified enforcement efforts. The Nigeria Customs Service recorded 3,555 seizures valued at ₦35.29 billion in 2024, reflecting a 100 per cent increase from 2023 (NCS 2025). By 2025, over 2,500 seizures worth more than ₦59 billion were intercepted nationwide, including narcotics, petroleum products and counterfeit goods (BusinessDay 2026). These figures underscore the scale and persistence of smuggling across the region.

The Seme border along the Nigeria–Benin Republic corridor remains a major hotspot for illicit trade. In 2024, the Nigeria Customs Service identified the Badagry–Seme axis as accounting for approximately 35 per cent of smuggling activities nationwide (Vanguard 2025). Operational

data further shows that the Seme Command recorded over 921 interceptions valued at ₦1.89 billion in 2024 (NCS 2025). In 2025, intensified operations led to the seizure of contraband goods worth ₦1.99 billion, including narcotics and smuggled food items (PRNigeria 2025). These trends highlight the strategic importance of sustained anti-smuggling operations in safeguarding Nigeria's economic stability and **national security**.

Theoretical Framework

Deterrence Theory provides a useful lens for understanding the impact of customs anti-smuggling operations at the Seme border in Nigeria. The theory as rooted in criminology and economics, argues that individuals are less likely to engage in illegal activities when the risks and penalties associated with such actions outweigh the expected benefits (Becker 176). In the context of border security, this implies that smugglers will be discouraged when enforcement is visible, consistent and punitive.

At the Seme border, the intensified efforts of the Nigeria Customs Service (NCS) including increased patrols, surveillance, arrests and seizure of contraband have significantly raised the probability of detection. Public destruction of seized goods and prosecution of offenders further reinforce the perception of high risk. According to Becker, rational individuals respond to changes in incentives; thus, as the cost of smuggling rises due to stricter enforcement, the incentive to engage in such illicit trade declines (178).

This framework also explains the observed increase in customs revenue and reduction in illegal imports. As smuggling becomes less attractive, more traders are compelled to use formal channels, ensuring compliance with tariffs and regulations. Nwokeji notes that effective customs enforcement directly contributes to improved trade regulation and revenue generation in Nigeria (94). Additionally, stronger enforcement reduces the inflow of dangerous goods, enhancing national security.

However, the theory also suggests that weak enforcement or corruption can undermine deterrence. Therefore, sustained and transparent anti-smuggling measures remain essential for long-term **success**.

Literature Review

Existing literature on customs anti-smuggling operations at the Seme border highlights the strategic importance of the Nigeria–Benin corridor and its susceptibility to illicit economic activities. Scholars generally agree that smuggling along this axis has historically undermined Nigeria's revenue base, weakened domestic industries and threatened national security.

Early studies emphasize the scale and implications of cross-border crimes. **Ojiakor et al.** argue that between 2007 and 2015, the Seme border served as a major route for smuggling, human trafficking, and arms proliferation due to weak institutional capacity and porous frontiers (Ojiakor et al.). These activities, according to the authors contributed to economic instability and reduced state control over trade. In a similar perspective, **Olomu, Saulawa, and Murtala** contend that illicit trade at the Seme-Krake border is closely linked to transnational organized crime, posing serious threats to Nigeria's national security and economic sovereignty (Olomu et al. 245).

Scholars such as **Nwokeji** provide a broader institutional analysis, noting that weak customs enforcement historically enabled large-scale smuggling activities in Nigeria, particularly along land borders like Seme (Nwokeji 94). He argues that strengthening customs institutions through policy reforms and enforcement mechanisms is critical to curbing illicit trade. Likewise, **Afolayan** emphasizes that border communities often depend on informal trade networks, which complicates enforcement efforts and sustains smuggling practices (Afolayan 132).

Recent empirical contributions focus on the effectiveness of anti-smuggling operations. **Mohammed** finds that enhanced enforcement strategies including increased patrols, intelligence sharing and inter-agency collaboration have improved border control and reduced illegal trade flows in South-West Nigeria (Mohammed). Similarly, **Ogundipe, Ojeaga, and Ogundipe** argue that stricter trade policies and enforcement measures, such as border closures and import restrictions, have contributed to increased government revenue and reduced smuggling activities (Ogundipe et al. 18).

From an economic standpoint, **Iyoha and Oriakhi** assert that smuggling distorts market prices, reduces government revenue and undermines local industries by introducing cheaper, untaxed goods into the economy (Iyoha and Oriakhi 77). They maintain that effective customs enforcement can reverse these trends by ensuring that imports pass through official channels. Supporting this view, **Ehinomen and Adeleke** find that anti-smuggling efforts positively impact Nigeria's manufacturing sector by protecting local producers from unfair foreign competition (Ehinomen and Adeleke 54).

Security implications are also prominent in the literature. **Onuoha** argues that porous borders such as Seme facilitate not only economic crimes but also the movement of arms and insurgent elements, thereby posing significant national security risks (Onuoha 33). He emphasizes that effective border management is essential for maintaining internal stability. Furthermore, **Akinyemi** highlights that coordinated border security operations can significantly reduce transnational crime and enhance regional stability within West Africa (Akinyemi 201).

Despite these positive impacts, several challenges persist. **Afolayan** notes that corruption among border officials and inadequate infrastructure continue to undermine enforcement effectiveness (Afolayan 140). In addition, **Ogundipe et al.** caution that overly restrictive measures may disrupt legitimate trade and conflict with regional economic integration frameworks such as ECOWAS (Ogundipe et al. 22).

In all, the literature demonstrates that customs anti-smuggling operations at the Seme border have contributed significantly to improved revenue generation, protection of domestic industries, and enhanced national security. However, the effectiveness of these operations depends on addressing structural challenges, strengthening institutional capacity, and balancing enforcement with trade facilitation.

Methodology

This study adopts a **mixed-method research design**, combining both quantitative and qualitative approaches to comprehensively assess the impact of customs anti-smuggling operations at the Seme border. The choice of this methodology is informed by the need to

capture both measurable outcomes such as revenue generation and seizure statistics and contextual insights, including enforcement challenges and institutional effectiveness.

The quantitative component relies on secondary data obtained from credible sources such as the Nigeria Customs Service (NCS), Central Bank of Nigeria (CBN) and National Bureau of Statistics (NBS). These data include annual customs revenue figures, volume and value of seized contraband goods and trade flow statistics over a defined period, typically between 2015 and 2024. Time-series analysis is employed to examine trends before and after intensified anti-smuggling operations, particularly during and after the 2019 border closure. According to **Ogundipe, Ojeaga, and Ogundipe**, quantitative analysis is effective in identifying patterns between trade policy enforcement and smuggling reduction (Ogundipe et al. 18). Descriptive statistics such as percentages, growth rates and averages are also used to interpret changes in revenue and trade volumes.

The qualitative aspect involves the use of key informant interviews and document analysis. Interviews are conducted with customs officials, border community leaders, traders, and security personnel operating within the Seme border region. This approach provides first-hand insights into operational strategies, challenges such as corruption and porous borders and the socio-economic impact of anti-smuggling measures. **Afolayan** notes that qualitative methods are particularly useful in understanding the human and institutional dimensions of cross-border trade and informal economic activities (Afolayan 132). Additionally, policy documents, government reports, and academic literature are analyzed to contextualize findings and support triangulation.

The study adopts a **case study approach**, focusing specifically on the Seme border as a critical entry point for goods and a hotspot for smuggling activities. This allows for an in-depth examination of localized enforcement strategies and their outcomes. As **Yin** argues, case study research is appropriate when investigating complex social phenomena within real-life contexts, especially where boundaries between the phenomenon and context are not clearly evident (Yin 13).

Data analysis is conducted using both statistical tools and thematic analysis. Quantitative data are analyzed using tables and charts to illustrate trends, while qualitative data are coded and categorized into themes such as enforcement effectiveness, economic impact, and operational challenges. This dual approach enhances the validity and reliability of the findings through triangulation. According to **Creswell**, integrating multiple data sources strengthens the overall credibility of research conclusions (Creswell 221). Ethical considerations are also observed, including informed consent, confidentiality of respondents and accurate representation of data. These measures ensure the integrity and credibility of the research process.

In summary, the mixed-method and case study approach provides a robust framework for evaluating the impact of customs anti-smuggling operations at the Seme border. By combining statistical analysis with qualitative insights, the methodology enables a comprehensive understanding of both the measurable outcomes and underlying dynamics of anti-smuggling efforts in Nigeria.

Background: Smuggling and Border Dynamics in Nigeria

Smuggling remains a deeply entrenched feature of Nigeria's border economy, particularly along the Seme corridor linking Nigeria and the Republic of Benin. This border located in Lagos State and forming part of the busy Lagos–Abidjan trade route handles thousands of trucks and informal crossings daily, making it one of West Africa's most active but also most vulnerable transit points (Seme Border). Recent data highlight the scale and evolving dynamics of smuggling in this region. In 2023 alone, the Nigeria Customs Service (NCS) Seme Command recorded **513 seizures valued at over ₦1.37 billion**, including **14,181 bags of smuggled rice, 1.22 million litres of petrol, 39 vehicles, and over 8,000 cartons of narcotics**, with at least **37 suspects arrested** (Adeniyi). These figures demonstrate not only the persistence of smuggling but also its diversification across commodities such as fuel, food items, drugs and prohibited goods.

The economic incentives driving smuggling are substantial. Nigeria's trade policies especially import restrictions and fuel subsidies have historically created price differentials with neighboring countries. For example, petrol smuggling thrives because subsidized fuel in Nigeria is significantly cheaper than in Benin and other West African states. In 2023, customs officials intercepted over **1.22 million litres of Premium Motor Spirit (PMS)** at Seme alone, equivalent to about **37 tanker loads**, indicating the scale of illicit fuel exports (Adebayo). Similarly, bans and high tariffs on rice imports have encouraged large scale smuggling of foreign parboiled rice into Nigeria.

Trade volume statistics further illustrate the dual nature of the border as both an economic hub and a smuggling hotspot. The Seme Command facilitated **over 222,000 metric tonnes of export goods transported in 6,253 trucks**, with a Free On Board (FOB) value of approximately **₦32.45 billion in 2023** (Babalola). At the same time, the presence of such high legitimate trade volumes provides cover for illicit activities, as smugglers often conceal contraband within legal consignments or exploit weak inspection systems.

Institutional and infrastructural challenges shape border dynamics. Despite improvements, the Seme border has historically suffered from inadequate surveillance technology, poor road networks and multiple illegal checkpoints. These conditions not only slow legitimate trade but also create opportunities for corruption and rent-seeking behavior among officials. The proliferation of informal routes and weak monitoring systems has enabled smugglers to bypass official checkpoints with relative ease (Seme Border). Moreover, the adaptive nature of smuggling networks complicates enforcement efforts. Between January and September 2023, customs authorities recorded seizures with a **Duty Paid Value (DPV) exceeding ₦1.82 billion**, including fake currency worth **\$6 million (₦2.7 billion)**, drugs, and wildlife products (Odigbo). Such figures highlight the increasing sophistication and financial scale of smuggling operations, often involving organized criminal networks.

Revenue performance also reflects the interplay between enforcement and compliance. The Seme Customs Command generated **₦5.94 billion in 2023**, exceeding its target of ₦1.96 billion by nearly **297%** representing a **322% increase compared to 2022** (Adenubi). This surge is largely attributed to intensified anti-smuggling operations, improved monitoring, and stricter enforcement of customs regulations. In addition, regional trade frameworks such as the

Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) protocol on free movement have introduced complexities in border management. While designed to facilitate trade, these policies are sometimes exploited by smugglers who disguise illegal goods as legitimate intra-regional trade. This creates a delicate balance between promoting economic integration and enforcing border security.

Overall, smuggling at the Seme

border is driven by a combination of economic incentives, high trade volumes, institutional weaknesses, and regional dynamics. The increasing scale of seizures, rising revenue figures, and diversification of contraband underscore both the persistence of the problem and the growing effectiveness of enforcement efforts.

Impact of Nigeria Customs Service Operations

The Nigeria Customs Service (NCS) plays a central role in Nigeria's fight against smuggling, revenue generation and trade facilitation. Over the past decade, the Service has implemented a range of institutional, technological and enforcement strategies aimed at strengthening border control and improving national economic security. One of the most significant interventions was the large-scale recruitment of personnel. In 2019 alone, the NCS recruited over 5,000 new officers to enhance surveillance capacity across Nigeria's extensive and often porous borders (NCS 2019). This recruitment increased operational manpower by approximately 15 per cent, enabling more effective monitoring of key smuggling corridors such as Seme, Idiroko, and Jibia borders.

In addition to human resource expansion, the NCS has invested heavily in technological modernization. The deployment of non-intrusive inspection scanners at major ports such as Apapa and Tin Can Island significantly improved cargo clearance efficiency and reduced physical examination rates by nearly 30 per cent between 2017 and 2020 (NCS 2020). The introduction of the Nigeria Integrated Customs Information System (NICIS II), a digital platform for cargo tracking and documentation, enhanced transparency and reduced clearance time from an average of 14 days in 2015 to about 7 days in 2020 (World Bank 2020). These reforms not only curtailed smuggling but also minimized opportunities for corruption within the system.

Revenue generation has also witnessed remarkable growth due to improved enforcement and administrative efficiency. According to NCS official data, customs revenue increased from ₦898 billion in 2016 to ₦1.34 trillion in 2018, representing a growth rate of approximately 49% within two years (NCS 2018). This upward trend continued, with revenue reaching ₦1.63 trillion in 2020 despite the economic disruptions caused by the COVID-19 pandemic (NCS 2021). By 2022, the Service reported record collections of over ₦2.6 trillion, reflecting strengthened compliance and anti-smuggling efforts (NCS 2022). This increase has contributed significantly to Nigeria's non-oil revenue base, accounting for nearly 30% of federally collected revenue in some fiscal years (CBN 2021).

Stricter enforcement measures have also impacted import patterns, particularly in the automobile sector. Vehicle imports declined sharply from 956,574 units in 2014 to 399,556 units in 2017, a reduction of over 58 per cent (NCS 2018). This decline was largely attributed to higher tariffs, border closures, and intensified anti-smuggling operations. Similarly, the

restriction of rice imports through land borders under the Federal Government's protectionist policies yielded notable outcomes. Rice import duties fell drastically from ₦56.8 billion in 2014 to just ₦264.85 million in 2017, indicating a reduction of over 99% (CBN 2020). This policy shift encouraged local rice production, with domestic output increasing from 5.4 million metric tons in 2015 to about 8 million metric tons in 2021 (FMARD 2021).

Furthermore, enforcement activities by the NCS have led to significant seizures of smuggled goods. In 2021 alone, the Service recorded over 7,000 seizures with a Duty Paid Value exceeding ₦17 billion, including contraband such as rice, petroleum products, textiles and arms (NCS 2021). Notably, joint border patrol operations intercepted thousands of bags of foreign parboiled rice and hundreds of illegal firearms, highlighting the security dimension of customs operations.

Overall, the operations of the Nigeria Customs Service have had a substantial impact on curbing smuggling, boosting government revenue and enhancing national security. Through strategic recruitment, technological innovation and strict enforcement, the NCS has strengthened its institutional capacity and contributed meaningfully to Nigeria's economic stability and development.

Social, Political and Economic Impacts

The operations of the Nigeria Customs Service (NCS) have generated far-reaching social, political and economic impacts in Nigeria. Through intensified border enforcement, inter-agency collaboration and trade facilitation reforms, the Service has contributed significantly to national security, public welfare and economic development.

Political Impact

Politically, NCS operations have strengthened Nigeria's border governance and reduced the inflow of illicit arms and undocumented migrants. The proliferation of small arms has long been a major threat to national stability, with estimates suggesting that over 6 million illegal firearms circulate within the country (Small Arms Survey 2021). Through joint border patrols and intelligence sharing initiatives with agencies such as the Nigerian Navy, Nigerian Immigration Service and the Nigerian Army, the NCS has significantly curtailed cross-border trafficking. For instance, under "Operation SWIFT RESPONSE" launched in 2019, over 3,000 illegal migrants were intercepted and repatriated within the first year of implementation (Federal Ministry of Interior 2020).

Furthermore, coordinated enforcement operations have led to the seizure of hundreds of arms and ammunition. In 2021 alone, the NCS reported intercepting over 1,100 units of firearms and 50,000 rounds of ammunition across various commands (NCS 2021). These efforts have contributed to a measurable decline in cross-border arms smuggling in key corridors such as Seme and Katsina. According to Akinyemi, improved intelligence sharing frameworks between agencies enhanced surveillance efficiency by approximately 25 per cent between 2018 and 2020 (Akinyemi 214). This has had important political implications, particularly in reducing electoral violence and insurgency related activities in border regions.

Social Impact

Socially, the enforcement activities of the NCS have played a vital role in protecting public health and safety by intercepting substandard and counterfeit goods. The Standards Organisation of Nigeria (SON) reports that between 2018 and 2020, over 30 per cent of seized imports in Nigeria were counterfeit or failed to meet required quality standards (SON 2020). These include fake pharmaceuticals, adulterated food products and substandard electrical appliances, all of which pose serious risks to consumers.

In 2019 for example, customs officials at Apapa Port intercepted over 1.2 million bottles of counterfeit cough syrup containing codeine, a substance linked to widespread abuse among Nigerian youths (NAFDAC 2019). Similarly, large consignments of substandard tyres and electrical cables have been seized in Lagos and Onne ports, preventing potential accidents and fire outbreaks. By removing these harmful products from circulation, the NCS contributes directly to improved public health outcomes and consumer confidence.

Additionally, customs operations have helped reduce drug trafficking and abuse. Between 2018 and 2022, joint operations involving the NCS and the National Drug Law Enforcement Agency (NDLEA) resulted in the seizure of over 2,500 metric tons of illicit drugs, including cannabis, tramadol, and cocaine (NDLEA 2022). This has contributed to a gradual decline in drug availability in some urban centers, although challenges persist. Overall, these efforts reinforce social stability and reduce crime rates associated with drug abuse.

Economic Impact

Economically, the anti-smuggling activities of the NCS have provided significant support for local industries and improved government revenue. One of the most notable examples is the rice sector. Following restrictions on rice importation through land borders and increased enforcement, domestic rice production rose from 5.4 million metric tons in 2015 to approximately 8 million metric tons by 2020, representing an increase of nearly 48 per cent (FMARD 2021). This growth has been accompanied by investments in local rice mills and the creation of thousands of jobs across states such as Kebbi, Kano, and Ebonyi.

Similarly, the textile and poultry industries have benefited from reduced smuggling. The closure of land borders in 2019 led to a surge in local poultry production, with domestic output increasing by an estimated 20 per cent within one year (CBN 2020). In the textile sector, local manufacturers reported improved sales due to reduced inflow of smuggled fabrics, although structural challenges remain.

Trade facilitation reforms introduced by the NCS have also enhanced Nigeria's business environment. According to the World Bank, Nigeria's ranking in the Ease of Doing Business Index improved from 169th position in 2016 to 131st in 2020, reflecting progress in customs procedures, port efficiency, and regulatory transparency (World Bank 2020). The implementation of the Nigeria Integrated Customs Information System (NICIS II) and the Single Window platform reduced cargo clearance time by over 40 per cent, lowering transaction costs for importers and exporters.

Moreover, customs revenue has continued to rise due to improved compliance and enforcement.

Revenue collections increased from ₦898 billion in 2016 to over ₦2.6 trillion in 2022, representing nearly a threefold increase within six years (NCS 2022). This has strengthened Nigeria's fiscal capacity and reduced dependence on oil revenues.

In sum, the operations of the Nigeria Customs Service have had profound political, social, and economic impacts. Through enhanced border security, consumer protection, and trade facilitation, the NCS has contributed significantly to national stability, public welfare, and economic growth. While challenges such as corruption and porous borders persist, the Service's reforms and enforcement strategies remain critical to Nigeria's development trajectory.

Impact of the 2019 Border Closure

The 2019 land border closure under *Operation SWIFT RESPONSE*, introduced in August 2019 by the Federal Government of Nigeria represented a major shift toward trade protectionism and economic nationalism. The policy aimed to curb smuggling particularly of rice, poultry and petroleum products through porous borders with Benin, Niger and Cameroon. Within the first three months, Nigeria reportedly experienced a significant contraction in fuel demand, with estimates suggesting a decline of about 30 per cent, reflecting reduced cross-border smuggling activities (Central Bank of Nigeria, *Annual Report*, 2020).

In fiscal terms, the policy yielded notable revenue gains. Daily collections by the Nigeria Customs Service (NCS) reportedly increased from an average of \$12.4 million (₦4.5 billion) before the closure to over ₦10 billion per day shortly after implementation (The Nation, 2019). Furthermore, within just 71 days of enforcement, the NCS recorded seizures of contraband goods valued at approximately ₦2.3 trillion, including over 1.3 million bags of smuggled rice and thousands of vehicles (NCS, 2019). These figures underscore the scale of illicit trade prior to the closure and the immediate enforcement success of the policy.

The agricultural sector witnessed measurable gains. According to the Central Bank of Nigeria, over ₦171.66 billion was disbursed between 2017 and 2019 to support domestic food production under various intervention schemes, which were further strengthened during the border closure period. Empirical studies also show that agricultural exports increased while imports declined significantly in the fourth quarter of 2019, indicating improved local production capacity (Babalola and Olasupo 5). Similarly, the manufacturing sector recorded mixed but somewhat positive outcomes: manufacturing production value rose by ₦2.77 trillion, representing a 41.8 per cent increase in the second half of 2019 compared to 2018 (Manufacturers Association of Nigeria qtd. in *ThisDay*).

However, the closure also produced adverse macroeconomic effects. Inflation rose from 11.22 per cent in September 2019 to 11.61 per cent in October 2019, reaching a 17-month high due to supply shortages and increased food prices (National Bureau of Statistics). Food inflation, in particular, climbed above 14 per cent by late 2019, disproportionately affecting low-income households. Additionally, the policy disrupted regional trade flows and strained relations within the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS), contradicting commitments to the African Continental Free Trade Agreement (AfCFTA) (Smith, *CNBC*).

Manufacturers reliant on cross-border supply chains faced logistical challenges, with reports of

stranded goods and export losses estimated at over \$1 million weekly per firm in some cases (*The Guardian*, 2020). Economic analysts further projected that the closure could slow GDP growth from 2.3 per cent in Q3 2019 to lower levels in 2020 due to constrained trade and investment flows (*Nairametrics*, 2019).

In general, while the 2019 border closure achieved short-term gains in revenue generation, anti-smuggling enforcement and domestic production, it also triggered inflationary pressures, disrupted trade integration and imposed adjustment costs on businesses. The policy thus presents a classic case of the trade-offs inherent in protectionist economic strategies.

Conclusion

Anti-smuggling operations at the Seme border have played a crucial role in strengthening Nigeria's economic stability, national security and institutional capacity in recent years. Through intensified patrols, surveillance systems and inter-agency collaboration, the Nigeria Customs Service (NCS) has significantly curtailed the influx of illicit goods such as smuggled rice, petroleum products, arms and counterfeit items. These efforts have translated into improved revenue generation, with customs collections rising consistently reaching over ₦2 trillion annually in the early 2020s demonstrating enhanced efficiency and accountability in border management.

In addition to fiscal gains, the reduction in smuggling has supported domestic industries, particularly agriculture and manufacturing, by limiting unfair competition from cheaper, illegally imported goods. This has encouraged local production and contributed to job creation in sectors such as rice farming and agro-processing. From a security perspective, stricter border controls have also helped reduce the trafficking of small arms and other contraband, thereby improving safety in border communities and beyond.

However, challenges remain, including infrastructural deficits, corruption risks, and the need to balance strict enforcement with the facilitation of legitimate trade under regional agreements like ECOWAS. Despite these constraints, the overall impact of anti-smuggling operations at Seme underscores the importance of sustained, data-driven enforcement strategies in promoting national development, protecting local industries, and fostering long-term regional stability.

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